# Copyright Statement

The Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College has made a reasonable effort to secure permission from the interviewees to make these materials available to the public. Use of these materials by other parties is subject to the fair use doctrine in United States copyright law (Title 17, Chapter 1, section 107), which states that use by “reproduction in copies or phonorecords or by any other means specified by that section [106 and 106A], for purposes such as criticism, comment, news reporting, teaching (including multiple copies for classroom use), scholarship, or research, is not an infringement of copyright."

Any use that does not fall within fair use must be cleared with the rights holder. For assistance in contacting the rights holder please contact the Fillius Jazz Archive, Hamilton College, 198 College Hill Road, Clinton, NY 13323 (phone: 315-859-4071).

# Christian McBride

*Bassist Christian McBride is one of the new stars of jazz. At the time of this interview he was 23 years of age and had already performed and recorded with Freddie Hubbard, Wynton Marsalis, Benny Green and vocalist Betty Carter. Following in his father's footsteps, he took up the bass at an early age and attended Philadelphia's School for the Performing Arts and was awarded a Julliard scholarship. New York musicians decided he was ready for the world of jazz and he made his premier with the Bobby Watson ensemble. He now leads his own quartet, and his first recording as a leader "Getting To It" spent twenty consecutive weeks on the* Billboard *jazz charts.*

*Christian McBride was interviewed in Sarasota, Florida on April 12, 1996 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.*

MR: We are filming this evening for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. It's a great pleasure to have Christian McBride join us, and for a hot set at the Sarasota Jazz Festival. I'm going to make a guess from listening to your answer machine a couple of times trying to reach you, that jazz was not your only influence when you were growing up.

CM: That's exactly right. You are referring to the scream you hear when my answer machine picks up, the scream of James Brown. Everyone seems to get awakened by that.

MR: The first time I heard it.

CM: James was my main man growing up in Philadelphia in the 70s, that's what the hot thing was in Philadelphia, Philly Soul. And of course my parents listened. My father is a bass player and he played on the R & B circuit in the 70s so that's definitely as much a part of me as is jazz.

MR: It was in your blood, and was it your great uncle who also plays bass?

CM: That's right. So it was destined.

MR: You can tell your musical influences just from the set you picked to play. You didn't have much time but you put in quite a group of things there.

CM: Well thank you. It was rough, I was getting nervous for a minute.

MR: Seeing that audience.

CM: Seeing the audience and I kept looking at the clock you know, my head was going back and forth, and tonight marks the debut of Joey Calderazzo as a member of the band so I was listening to Joey, watching the audience and watching the clock at the same time. So it was rough.

MR: Well your James Brown step came off. You know I think it's a — I like the way you talk to the audience and I think it's something that a lot of musicians don't have. It's important.

CM: Well you know I've always believed that presentation is just as important as the music sounding good, I mean because I mean people like it when you try to communicate to them and try to explain a little of what's going on and you know they like that so that draws them in to the music even more. I mean the music has to be good first and foremost. I mean if the music is not happening it doesn't mean anything. But when the music is sounding good and you verbally try to communicate to the audience, they really appreciate that.

MR: This album has some great things on it. It was wonderful to see Milt Hinton and Ray Brown. That must have been quite a thrill to do.

CM: Well fortunately it wasn't a complete surprise because we actually played together before, before we did the album. So I kind of knew what to expect. I mean Ray is more or less my Godfather so Ray and I have been close for so long. And Milt Hinton is such a wonderful man. They made me feel completely comfortable at my session.

MR: Do you write your tunes from the piano? Because as I was walking down the hall to find you I heard this pretty mean piano and there you were behind it.

CM: Well more than half of the tunes that I've written tend to start on the piano, just because I've always been influenced by piano players and saxophone players. So on the piano I get to see and just hear the whole orchestra, where the harmonies and the chords are going. So most of the time they tend to start on the piano. But there've been a couple of songs that I've written that started on the bass.

MR: What is the state of jazz in New York for you right now? Does it seem pretty healthy?

CM: Well you know a friend of mine said something that was very true. You have to move to New York to work out of New York.

MR: Once you get there you find yourself going somewhere.

CM: Exactly. So in the last few years now I've been pretty much road running, which is great I mean that's what I've always wanted to do my whole life and I thank God for it. But you know usually when I'm in New York these days, when I'm home I'm doing a few recording sessions or you know just catching up on bills or all of that fun stuff.

MR: Well in the span of a few years you've been with some pretty good bands.

CM: Fortunately.

MR: How did all that happen?

CM: Let's see. I first met Wynton Marsalis when I was fifteen years old, fourteen years old. He came to Philadelphia to do a workshop with the local Philadelphia high school students. And Wynton was like a mentor for all of the young high school students. However I was probably one of the only ones that had all of his albums and knew every song off of all of those albums. So I tried to impress him by playing a song off of the record. I can't remember which one it was but I caught him. And from that point on he

became like my big brother. I mean he used to go so far as to call my teachers at school to make sure I was getting good grades. So Wynton was definitely someone that I needed. Wynton is someone that everyone needs in their life, especially when you're that young you know, to have a mentor like that that takes you under their wing and just set you straight.

MR: Keep you on the right track.

CM: Exactly. And then after meeting Wynton I met his brother Branford and I met Bobby Watson. I had a chance to meet a lot of great musicians as they came through Philadelphia to do different workshops. There was an annual workshop that goes on, a jazz festival rather that goes on in Philadelphia every year, sponsored by Mellon Bank, the Mellon Jazz Festival. And every year before they have the big gala concert they have all of the players come and do workshops for the high school students. So I had a chance to meet and play with like Red Rodney and Kenny Barron, Curtis Fuller, Jimmy Heath, Walter Davis Jr., I first met Ron Carter with the Mellon Jazz Festival. So I mean that festival brought a lot of high school students who wanted to go, you know, in touch with these musicians. And that was fantastic you know. Because like I say you need that when you're that young.

MR: Did you start out on acoustic?

CM: No.

MR: You started on —

CM: I started on electric bass. And I started to play the acoustic bass when I was eleven when I started going to junior high school. So ever since then I still pretty much do a juggling act. You know the gigs that I've had in the last few years never called for electric bass so I just never had a chance to play it in public. So a lot of people forgot that I still play electric bass because I used to play with a band, everyone always kids me about this, actually I only did a few gigs with them, but I used to play in this fusion band called Free Flight. A flute player named Jimmy Walker and Mike Garson the piano player, and Alex Acuna played drums. And that group was more or less like kind of a Weather Reportish type group. And I played some electric bass in Joshua Redman's band. So on the new album which is coming out in a few days, I'm playing electric bass on some of it, just to keep the chops nice and greased up you know.

MR: Well with your father playing rhythm & blues, and you being a James Brown fan, how was it that you got an interest in "Stars Fell on Alabama" for instance?

CM: My great uncle, the bass player. He was the man in the family that had all of the albums. So when he discovered I was taking acoustic bass lessons in junior high school he was so happy, he brought me over a big stack of albums to listen to. He said, "Well now that you're playing the acoustic bass, I want you to listen to these records." So the one record

that was in there that changed my life forever was the Massey Hall Concert with Bird and Dizzy, Bud Powell, Charles Mingus and Max Roach. And the group sound of that record. You know because I mean I was, we're talking like 1984, so I was into Prince and Michael Jackson, everything that was hot at that time. And I still listen to that as well as checking out Bird and Miles and it was a different kind of energy. But the joy and the feeling was still there. So fortunately I was able to latch on to it you know. And then I heard bass players like Ron Carter and Paul Chambers and I said man, so that's how this instrument is supposed to be played.

MR: Is it more of a physical challenge to play the acoustic bass?

CM: I think being as young and naive as I was at the age of eleven I wasn't aware of the level of intimidation I should have had at that time. I just thought of it as being an oversized electric bass. So when I went to junior high school I just said oh, well, you know, I'll just do what I do at home. You know I didn't realize the switch that I should have been thinking about. But I think in that case it worked in my favor, because I wasn't scared of it.

MR: I hope you didn't have one of those typical junior high instruments where the strings are two inches off the —

CM: Oh, yea, of course. Fiberglass. A fiberglass bass.

MR: Well you must have developed a lot of strength.

CM: You had to.

MR: When you came to get a chance to do your own record and you sit down and you say now this is important, what's going to go on this? So you kind of balanced your own originals with some classic standards?

CM: Well you know I purposely tried to wait as long as I possibly — I tried to pick the time where I said okay well the time is right now. Because I actually had a chance to do my first record maybe six years ago when this quote unquote young lions craze started to happen with Roy Hargrove and Antonio Hart and all of us came on the scene together. And as you well know, record companies started making it a hot commodity. So they were just handing out record contracts just because guys were under 21. And I didn't want to be a part of that because I had already had a chance to be around really serious musicians like Wynton and Branford and Bobby Watson. And I see the effort and the sweat and the grit that they put into making their music and I just know going to the studio and making a quick record, a quick, sad record, wouldn't be good for the legacy of the music. So I said well I just want to be able to play with as many different people as I can and get more experience so when it comes time for me to make my record I'll have some, I'll know what I'm doing to some extent.

MR: That's a great attitude I think. Who were some of the horn players that caught your ear when you got into jazz?

CM: Freddie Hubbard. Freddie Hubbard was probably my biggest non-bass influence as far as writing, as far as improvising. I first heard Freddie's CTI Records like "Red Clay" and all that stuff, and I heard the records he made with Art Blakey and I heard his Blue Note records. And then when I saw him in person I'll never forget, I almost passed out because I'd never seen anyone play with that much — that was my first time actually witnessing a jazz musician with that much fire playing in person. And I remember I almost fell over in my chair and from that point on I said I want to play with Freddie Hubbard. And it's amazing how fate happens, because Carl Allen was in the band at that time and Carl Allen and I became best friends and we started working with Benny Green. Actually I started working with Freddie first. I moved to New York in 1989, and Carl knew how bad I wanted to play with Freddie. And their bass player was about to leave the band, so Carl, I was still going to Juilliard at the time, and Carl said, "Hey man, you want to make this gig with Freddie in South Carolina?" I said "What! Yes!" So I joined Freddie's band and I stayed in his band for about two and a half or three years and that was probably the most memorable musical experience I've had in my life.

MR: You got your education right there.

CM: Yes.

MR: That's fabulous. You are doing one of his tunes on your next record, right?

CM: That's right. "Little Sunflower." And not only because it's a great tune but the way I did it on the album, it's a little different. I did these multi-layering and overdubs so when you hear "Little Sunflower" you hear four acoustic basses and one electric bass and Mino Cinelu is playing percussion, and I just thought that "Little Sunflower" would be a perfect song to lend itself for bass and percussion, and I hope Freddie likes it.

MR: I hope he does too.

CM: I'm sure he will. I think I know what he likes and what he doesn't.

MR: Tell us about the new record coming out in just a few days.

CM: Yeah the new record is called "Number Two Express" and I'm so excited, I'm so excited, because you know the new album represents me where I am now musically — things I like to listen to and things I like to go for and the things that I would like to eventually have the band get into. You know I've always been about diversity. You know you can't be in just one bag. And I try to make a conscious effort for my band to play you know lots of blues and some progressive stuff maybe some things leaning to a funk, and then playing all the standards. You know, cover all the areas, because the legacy of jazz is so huge, I mean you just can't stick to one part of it. And especially people's, the general public's ignorance level toward jazz is so high you have to let them hear more than one

bag so they'll know what it's all about. And you know on the new album I have Chick Corea playing acoustic and electric piano and one of the best things about that was him and Jack DeJohnette got to play together again, because Jack is on the album also. And they hadn't worked together. They told me they'd maybe played together maybe three or four times since 1969. And it was such a thrill for me to have them record on my new CD. And Kenny Garret is on it as well playing alto saxophone. And on the other half of the album, Gary Bartz is playing alto saxophone, Steve Nelson is playing vibes, Kenny Barron is playing piano and Jack is on drums. And we're really stretching out. See on my first album, "Getting To It" was really a rootsy type album. You know I see recording as a tree. You know, you make your first album, those are your roots. And each album something grows out of that. So the second record is different from the first record and you know the third record I'm sure will be different from the second and so forth and so on. So you know, evolution.

MR: Really. You've got "Night Train" on there and I said all right, "Night Train." A classic blues thing. I was wondering, like how is he going to do this? And it's just bass, right?

CM: Yeah. Every time I think about how I did it I get tired. Because I did the same thing on the new album as I did on "Getting To It." The producer said, "Well you know why don't you feature yourself on something, you know, just unaccompanied bass?" I said well sometimes — this is not a good habit — sometimes it works out and sometimes it doesn't, but I tend to wait until the last minute to do some things. So things get so backed up and sometimes I don't get to things until the last minute. So I didn't really think of an arrangement for myself until maybe two days before I was supposed to go into the studio. So the producers kept saying, you know, "What do you got, what do you got?" I said, "Uhhh, it's a surprise, I'll tell you." So come the day of the session — oh I remember how it happened — getting to it took three days. So we figured we would knock all of the ensemble stuff out on the first two days and I'd do my solo piece and the stuff with Ray Brown and Milt Hinton on the last day. The session went so smoothly, the bulk of the album was finished after the first day.

MR: Just like the old time.

CM: Right. So they said, "Well look, Christian you have all this time, why don't you do your solo now?" I said, "Uhhh, can I wait, please?" They said, "No, why don't you do it today?" I said, "Okay." So I took my bass in the back and I said, "Give me about twenty minutes." So I figured out this arrangement of "Night Train" on the spur of the moment. And it really takes a lot of energy. I really backed myself up into a jam because sometimes people, like you know they ask me to play it in person. That takes a lot of energy, man.

MR: How many takes did it take you?

CM: I did three takes. Yeah. I had my heart beating fast and I was sweating and carrying on. And the same thing happened on the new album when I did "Little Sunflower" because you know, once again they said, "What's your bass feature going to be?" I said, "Ohhh, you'll see." But once again it worked out.

MR: You've got some good looking things in your future I see, playing with some notable people coming up?

CM: I hope so. Yeah, well actually I'll be touring with Chick Corea this summer. He's putting together a tribute to Bud Powell. We're going to go out with a group and we're going to play pretty much all Bud Powell music. And the band consists of myself, Roy Haynes is playing drums, Wallace Roney is playing trumpet, Joshua Redman is going to do most of the tour, but Kenny Garrett is going to play saxophone on a few concerts. So I'm really looking forward to playing with Chick this summer. Oh, that's going to be a blast. And also I'll be touring with Kathleen Battle at the end of the year and that'll be interesting because I had a chance to work with Kathleen on her latest, I guess it's her latest CD on the SONY Classics label in which she did a lot of very different — it turned out to be a great project — she did some Brazilian music, some spiritual, some stuff that's what she said was not strictly classical. So I played on it, Cyrus Chestnut played piano, James Carter plays saxophone and Grover Washington and it turned out to be a really marvelous project. So we're going to do a few concerts at the end of the year with that. And so in between Chick and Kathleen, I'll be touring with my band.

MR: Quite a schedule. Do you have any time to practice?

CM: Got to practice while you're out.

MR: Yeah. Miles said you practice on the gig.

CM: That's right.

MR: Wow. This has been really fascinating. I appreciate your joining us. Our viewers don't know but it's what about 12:30 at night right now.

CM: That's right.

MR: Someday we'll have to hook you up with a good friend of ours at Hamilton is Joe Williams, and he has actually mentioned your name a couple of times, and —

CM: You're kidding.

MR: Yeah, I think so.

CM: Oh yeah? Oh man, that's good news. I had a chance to work with him once at the White House. They had the fortieth anniversary of the Newport Jazz Festival. That was a huge event, on public television stations and Joe Williams was there and Clark Terry, Wynton Marsalis, John Lewis, Herbie Hancock, Bobby McFerrin, Bill Clinton played saxophone on "All Blues." It was funny.

MR: And you were there?

CM: Yeah.

MR: Oh, man.

CM: It was a thrill.

MR: That's one for the scrapbook I guess.

CM: That's right.

MR: It's interesting, just to wrap this up, but it seems sometimes your listening tastes and I'm talking generally, sometimes to work backwards, like you know you start out with a certain thing and then you find out where that went — where'd that come from? And where'd that come from?

CM: Well that's like I said, evolution. You know that's what happens, the natural evolution of your ideas happens from things that happen before then and before then and before that and before that. You know. So we'll see what happens in the future. The biggest thing I'm planning for right now is I'm actually already planning my third album. As you know and as I've said earlier, James Brown has always been my childhood hero, and it would be the dream of a lifetime to record with James Brown. But I would think how, you know, because it would be too easy to just get a funk band and just do covers. You know that's too easy. I said well you know James Brown has always said how much jazz has influenced his music. You know people like Jimmy Smith and Horace Silver, Les McCann. So I thought about doing a jazz album with James Brown, and doing like some pop standards. Because even during his heyday in the 60s, he was singing songs like "That's Life," "I Want To Be Around," "Kansas City." So we'll see what happens.

MR: Sounds like a good concept.

CM: Yeah.

MR: Well I want to wish you luck with your next album and if it does as good as this one, you know —

CM: Well we'll see.

MR: Thanks so much for joining us on behalf of Hamilton College it's been a real pleasure and I hope you have a safe trip back tomorrow and all your plans this summer go real well.

CM: Thank you very much. I hope to come and visit the college soon.

MR: That would be nice.

CM: Beautiful.

MR: All right.

CM: Thanks.